

CORE FORMULA

Good to see you. No rush - how has the day landed so far? -> I'm glad we get a minute properly. What's been taking most of your attention? -> Before I jump into my bit, how are you seeing it? -> No pressure to go deep, but I'm curious what your take is. -> Settle -> orient -> warm opener -> low-pressure invitation -> responsive follow-up.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Slow down, orient to them, and make one low-pressure warm comment before your question or point.

BEST FOR

- First impressions, introductions, dates, networking, ward/clinic or workplace conversations, and social settings.
- Opening a conversation before asking, persuading, challenging, or giving feedback.
- Shy, guarded, stressed, high-status, or socially cautious people who need lower pressure.
- Repairing a slightly tense, awkward, or cold interaction.
- Making competence feel approachable rather than intimidating.

PHRASE BANK

Openers · Warm greetings

- "Good to see you."
- "I'm glad we actually get a minute properly."
- "Nice to finally meet you properly."
- "I've heard good things - no pressure to live up to them."
- "Before we get into the details, how has your day been landing?"

Low-pressure warmth · Reduce pressure / shy or guarded

- "No rush - take your time."
- "No pressure if you don't want to get into it."
- "We can keep this light."
- "Only if you feel like saying."
- "A short version is completely fine."
- "You can give me the rough version."
- "We can start simple."
- "Whatever comes to mind first is fine."

Warm attention · Acknowledge and track

- "That makes sense."
- "I can see why that would land that way."
- "That sounds like the part that mattered."
- "I'm with you."
- "That's a useful way to put it."

Professional / leadership · Work and decisions

- "Before I give my view, how are you seeing it?"
- "What would make this useful from your side?"
- "Let's keep this practical."
- "I want to understand the constraint before suggesting anything."
- "What does good look like here?"

- "Would be curious for your take when you have space."

High-status or busy person · Brief, respectful asks

- "I'll keep this tight."
- "The short version is..."
- "I want to be respectful of your time."
- "I'd value your read on one thing."
- "If now's not the right time, no issue."

Dating / social · Playful rapport

- "No pressure, but I'm curious about that."
- "That sounds like there's a story there."
- "You seem like you have a good read on people."
- "I like how you said that."
- "Okay, give me the non-boring version."

Conflict softening · Lower the temperature

- "I want to understand before I respond."
- "I don't want this to become adversarial."
- "I can see there's a real concern underneath this."
- "Let's slow it down for a second."
- "I'm not trying to dismiss the concern."

Recovery / reset · Repair a cold moment

- "That came out colder than I meant."
- "Let me say that with less rush."
- "I think I moved too quickly into the task."
- "I don't want this to feel pressured."
- "Let me reset and ask properly."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "So what's the issue?"
Better: "Where should we start?"
Best: "No rush - give me the rough version first. What's been taking most of your attention?"
- Weak: "I need your answer quickly."
Better: "I'll keep this brief."
Best: "I want to be respectful of your time. The short version is..."
- Weak: "Tell me how you feel."
Better: "How has that been landing?"
Best: "No pressure to make it neat - what's the honest version?"
- Weak: "Relax, it's fine."
Better: "Take a second."
Best: "No rush. We can slow this down and work out the useful part first."

DECISION TREE

If They are giving a warmth cue - a first meeting, an awkward or cold moment, or someone who seems guarded, stressed or cautious.

Use the minimum viable move: slow down, orient, and make one low-pressure warm comment before your ask.
"Good to see you. No rush - how has the day landed so far?"

If There is no warmth cue - they want a direct answer, or the moment needs a boundary or safety action first.

Skip the warm-up. Listen plainly or lead with clarity, then add warmth once the essential point is made.
"Let me be straight with you first, then we can talk it through."

If The warm opener landed and they relaxed or opened up.

Stay with their first real thread once; reflect it back before adding your own point.

"So the people side is the main weight right now?"

If There is pressure, distress or urgency.

Under pressure, slow down and shorten. Under distress, add validation. Under real urgency, prioritise the action and keep the tone kind.

"No rush. We can slow this down and work out the useful part first."

If You have already used warmth and it is starting to feel like performance or stalling.

Do not repeat it mechanically. Switch to a clear summary, a direct request, or an ordinary contribution.

"Alright - here's what I'd actually suggest we do."

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Use the smallest natural version so the other person feels heard without being analysed. — "Good to see you. No rush - how's the day been?"

Professional discussion

Keep it concise and tie the warmth to the task, decision or concern. — "Before I give my view, how are you seeing it?"

Conflict or objection

Add validation and reduce speed; do not weaponise the warmth. — "Let's slow it down for a second. I want to understand before I respond."

Digital message

Use one sentence. Avoid long explanations or stacked questions. — "Quick thought - no pressure if it's not useful."

Shy or guarded person

Make the move lighter, more tentative and lower pressure. — "Whatever comes to mind first is fine."

High-status or busy person

Keep the wording brief, grounded and useful. — "I'll keep this tight. I'd value your read on one thing."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The situation needs immediate directness, safety action, or a firm boundary before rapport.
- Warmth is becoming approval-seeking, flattery, over-smiling, or excessive accommodation.
- You are using warmth to hide an agenda or soften pressure rather than preserve real choice.
- The other person is suspicious of charm; use calm clarity and consistency instead.
- You need to say no, correct, or disagree; keep warmth, but do not dilute the message.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Settle before you speak

Before your first three conversations today, take one slow breath and relax your jaw and shoulders. Notice whether your opening line comes out calmer.

Day 2 — Slow the first sentence

In five conversations, deliberately slow your opening sentence by about ten percent and start with a low-pressure line rather than a task or a question.

Day 3 — Phone-away attention

Put your phone fully away before the first meaningful question in each conversation. Notice what changes in how the other person responds.

Day 4 — The 'No rush' probe

Use the phrase "No rush" once with someone who seems pressured, then watch whether they relax, slow down, or elaborate.

Day 5 — Match before leading

Pick one quiet or guarded person and match their pace and volume before adding any energy of your own. Only lead once they have settled.

Day 6 — Warm and clear together

Have one conversation where you must give a boundary, correction, or firm ask. Keep your tone warm while stating the point cleanly - do not soften it into vagueness.

Day 7 — Review and calibrate

Afterwards, note for each conversation whether your warmth was genuine, performative, too intense, or well-calibrated, and pick the one cue you most want to read faster next week.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I make the person feel at ease before I asked for something?
- Did my face, tone, body, and words match?
- Did I lower pressure or accidentally increase it?
- Did I confuse warmth with agreeability?
- Did I stay clear when a boundary or point was needed?
- What cue told me to soften, slow down, or become more direct?